

Transitive & Intransitive Verb Pairs

What is the difference?

Transitive verbs (他動詞 / tadoushi) take a direct object — someone or something performs the action on someone or something else.

Intransitive verbs (自動詞 / jidoushi) do not take a direct object — the subject experiences or performs the action on its own, with no outside force implied.

Example sentences using 変える / 変わる:

Transitive (変える — kaeru)

私はスケジュールを変えました。

Watashi wa sukejuuru wo kaemashita.

I changed the schedule. → Something (I) acts on an object (the schedule)

Intransitive (変わる — kawaru)

スケジュールが変わりました。

Sukejuuru ga kawarimashita.

The schedule changed. → the schedule itself changed; no outside force mentioned

Tip: transitive verbs typically use を. Intransitive verbs typically use が. This is one of the most reliable clues for which you're dealing with.

#	Romaji	English	Hiragana	Kanji	T / I
Pair 1 · to change / to be changed					
1	kaeru (ichidan)	to change			T
2	kawaru	to change / be changed			I
Pair 2 · to open / to open (itself)					
3	akeru (ichidan)	to open			T
4	aku	to open / come open			I
Pair 3 · to close / to close (itself)					
5	shimeru (ichidan)	to close			T
6	shimaru	to close / be closed			I
Pair 4 · to turn on / to turn on (itself)					
7	tsukeru (ichidan)	to turn on / attach			T
8	tsuku	to turn on / be attached			I
Pair 5 · to turn off / to go off					
9	kesu	to turn off / erase			T
10	kieru (ichidan)	to go off / disappear			I
Pair 6 · to put out / to come out					
11	dasu	to take out / produce			T
12	deru	to come out / leave			I
Pair 7 · to put in / to enter					
13	ireru (ichidan)	to put in / insert			T
14	hairu	to enter / go in			I
Pair 8 · to begin / to begin					
15	hajimeru (ichidan)	to begin			T

#	Romaji	English	Hiragana	Kanji	T / I
16	hajimaru	to begin / start			I
Pair 9 · to end / to end*					
17	owaru	to finish			T
18	owaru	to end / be over			I
Pair 10 · to break / to break					
19	kowasu	to break / destroy			T
20	kowareru (ichidan)	to break / be broken			I
Pair 11 · to drop / to fall					
21	otosu	to drop			T
22	ochiru (ichidan)	to fall / drop			I
Pair 12 · to boil / to boil					
23	wakasu	to boil			T
24	waku	to boil / come to a boil			I

T = Transitive (他動詞) · I = Intransitive (自動詞)

*** Pair 9 note:** 終わる (owaru) is one of the few verbs that functions as both transitive and intransitive depending on context. Listen for を vs が to determine which is intended.